Q+A

A Blend of East & West

Filmmaker ***Gurinder Chadha*** *on* Christmas Karma, *a multicultural adaptation of Dickens's* A Christmas Carol



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Q. Looking back from *Bhaji on the Beach* to *Christmas Karma*, how do you see your journey?

I feel like I've been chronicling our histories, with each film being a document of its time on identity, migration and belonging. The industry has changed, and there are more women now, which is encouraging, but our stories still fight for space. Even today, getting a film made feels like a small miracle.

Q. Was filmmaking your childhood dream?

Absolutely not. I wanted to be a long-distance lorry driver! I loved the idea of being alone on open roads, in charge of a massive truck. The real turning point came when, as a student, I interned in Delhi at a magazine and read a powerful paper on how Indian women were portrayed in the media. The representations were so clichéd that they shook me. That's when I knew I wanted to get behind the camera and change those narratives myself.

Q. Why did you reimagine *A Christmas Carol*?

I wanted to make a holiday film rooted in compassion and redemption. I've always loved *It's a Wonderful Life*, which also draws from Dickens. I went back to the source, but placed it within a painful historical chapter—the expulsion of Indians from Uganda in the 1970s and their resettlement in Britain.

Q. How was it to work with such an extraordinary international cast?

Actors like Kunal Nayyar, Eva Longoria and Boy George were an absolute joy. Shaznay Lewis, who worked on *Bend It Like Beckham*, composed original music. We had Panjabi MC, Anoushka Shankar, Gary Barlow, Boy George, Malkit Singh, as well as Priyanka Chopra, singing songs.

—with ***Deepa Natarajan Lobo***